

and graphics. They are also almost silent in operation. Inkjet printers have a much lower initial cost than laser printers, but have a much higher cost-per-copy, as the ink needs to be frequently replaced.

In addition, consumer printer manufacturers have adapted a business model similar to that employed by razor blade manufacturers. The printers themselves are frequently sold below cost, and the ink is then sold at a high mark-up.

Various legal and technological means are employed to try and force users to purchase ink only from the manufacturer (thus leading to vendor lock-in). However there is a thriving aftermarket for such things as third-party ink cartridges (new or refurbished) and refill kits.

Inkjet printers are also far slower than laser printers. Inkjet printers also have the disadvantage that pages must be allowed to dry before being aggressively handled. Premature handling can cause the inks (which are adhered to the page in liquid form) to run.

Solid Ink printers, also known as phase-change printers, are a type of thermal transfer printer. They use solid sticks of CMYK coloured ink (similar in consistency to candle wax), which are melted and fed into a piezo-crystal operated print-head. The print head sprays the ink on a rotating, oil coated drum. The paper then passes over the print drum, at which time the image is transferred, or transfixed, to the page.

Solid Ink printers are most commonly used as colour office printers, and are excellent at printing on transparencies and other non-porous media. Solid ink printers can produce excellent results. Acquisition and operating costs are similar to laser printers. Drawbacks of the technology include high power consumption and long warm-up times from a cold state.